

The Nail Box

by Douglxss Burley Johnson

Hand me that dry cedar. The wind off the Lehigh is coming up the bank the way it always does once the sun drops behind the South Mountain ridge, and I want this fire high enough to keep the canal damp from settling in your coats. We're sitting on the Freemansburg flats, between Main Street and Lock 44, where the towpath still holds the shape of mule work and the locktender's stone house keeps its aluminum roof the color of old tin. You can smell river water and wet leaves and somebody's leaf pile burning two blocks over. My name is Cole Bachman. I'm thirty-two. This is about the nail box I found in my father's garage three weeks after we buried him, and about what his cut list left me to do with my hands.

Frank Bachman framed houses and hung doors from Bethlehem Township out past Hellertown until his shoulders quit, and after that he took smaller jobs, porch rails and kitchen cabinets and the kind of repair work a man can still do when the bone spurs start talking. He lived in a brick half-double on Main Street with the canal behind the back fence, and the garage was a cinder-block box he'd poured himself in '89, with a steel door that stuck in August and a

workbench along the north wall that still held the shape of his elbows. He died on a Tuesday in September of a heart that had been warning him for a year. I cleared the house with my sister Rita through the first two weekends of October. Rita took the kitchen and the upstairs closets. I took the garage.

I want you to see that garage the way it was the morning I opened it. The concrete floor held oil stains in the shape of a Ford that hadn't lived there since 2011. Cobwebs ran from the fluorescent fixture to the pegboard. A coffee can of mixed bolts sat on the second shelf with the lid half dented. A carpenter's pencil stub lay in the dust under the bench, chewed at one end the way Dad chewed when he was thinking about a joint. That pencil is one of the true things, and it does no other work in this story except sit there where he left it.

Rain from the night before had left a dark line along the base of the block wall facing the canal. I swept that line with a push broom before I touched a shelf, because Dad hated leaving a wet floor under stored wood. The broom head knocked a bottle cap out from under the bench, a Vernors cap from who knows which summer, and I kicked it toward the door and kept sweeping. Outside, beyond the chain-link, the towpath was empty except for a woman walking a beagle, and the beagle stopped to smell the fence post Dad used to prop open when he was staining shutters.

I started with the easy shelves. Paint cans came down first, then a coil of garden hose that still held a kink from the last time he'd wound it, then two boxes of Christmas lights Rita said she wanted for her porch. The fluorescent ballast hummed and clicked. My shoulders were already tight from the coffin week and the relatives and the cold cuts in the kitchen, and the garage work gave my arms a job my mouth didn't have to do. Then I pulled a stack of leftover trim off the far

pegs, white paint chipped along the edges, and behind the trim, on a high shelf where the dust was thickest, I found the nail box.

It was a wooden tray with a hinged lid and six compartments, the kind a finish carpenter keeps for brads and finish nails and the odd screw he doesn't want rolling. The wood was maple, darkened by oil and years of palms. On the lid, in Dad's block print, a black Sharpie had left four words: CUT LIST INSIDE. KEEP SQUARE. I set the box on the workbench and thumbed the hook open.

Four compartments held nails the way you'd expect: sixteen-penny commons, eight-penny finishes, a handful of roofing nails with the wide heads, and one empty slot with a clean wood floor, as if he'd left room on purpose. Under the nails, folded to fit the tray, lay a softcover Gospel of John, the little pocket kind churches give out free, the cover worn white at the corners. Dad's handwriting filled the margins the way he marked a cut list on a sheet of OSB before he touched a saw.

I sat on the stool and read it with the garage door open and the canal light coming in gray.

He didn't write sermons. He wrote measurements.

Beside John 5, where Jesus answered the men who hated Him for healing on the Sabbath and called God His own Father, Dad had printed in a single block: MY FATHER / NOT OUR / EQUAL CLAIM / CHECK JOINT. Beside John 8:58, where Jesus said He was before Abraham, the margin held I AM / BEFORE THE BOARD WAS LAID. At John 10:30, The Father and I are one, he'd written SAME STOCK / SQUARE TRUE OR THROW THE STICK. At John 14:6, the way and the truth and the life: NO BYPASS / ONLY RUN. Beside Thomas in John 20, where the doubter put his fingers to the wounds and called Him Lord and God, the margin said ACCEPT OR REJECT / NO MIDDLE KERF.

On the blank inside back cover Dad had drawn a little cut list the way he'd draw one for a set of cabinet sides:

CLAIM: GOD IF LIE: LIAR IF MAD: LUNATIC IF TRUE: LORD GOOD TEACHER
= BAD JOINT NO 4TH CUT

I sat with that book open on the maple while the canal made its slow sound behind the fence. A towpath runner went by in a yellow jacket. A train horn blew once from the tracks across the river toward Bethlehem. My father's handwriting was the same block print he'd used on every job ticket I ever saw taped inside a kitchen door. I turned a few more pages and found, at John 1, a small grease thumbprint at the bottom corner, dark and old, as if he'd read that opening with a hand still dirty from a morning hang.

I slid the Gospel back under the nails, shut the lid, and finished the morning's sorting. Rita got the short version at lunch, which was only that Dad had left a marked John in his nail box. She pressed her lips together and went back to wrapping plates in newspaper. She was already crying enough for both of us over Mom's old baking pans.

That Saturday a few of the guys from a punch-list job I'd been on in Bethlehem came by the half-double to help me haul the heavy stuff. Derek brought his truck. Manny brought gloves and a six-pack he left in the cooler on the porch because Rita doesn't like beer in the house since Dad's heart. We cleared leftover lumber, an old table saw with a rust freckle on the throat plate, and a cast-iron vise that weighed as much as a small engine. My lower back told me about the vise all the way down the driveway. When the light went and the work was done, Derek said we ought to build a fire down by the canal bank the way we used to in high school. Rita said fine if we kept it in the ring and didn't burn the neighbor's fence. I carried the nail box out with me

because I hadn't decided what to do with it and I didn't want it sitting alone on that bench overnight.

You need to know Derek. Derek is a good man with a framing nailer and a kid in Tee Ball. He goes to a church in Bethlehem when his wife makes him, and he likes Jesus the way a lot of men like Jesus, which is to say he likes the parts about being kind and he skips the parts where Jesus talks like God. We got the fire going with scrap pine from Dad's pile and a sheet of newspaper from the Morning Call. The lock house stood dark across the water. Main Street's porch lights came on one at a time. Manny roasted a hot dog on a bent hanger. Derek sat on an overturned five-gallon bucket and cracked a can. A moth kept circling the nearest porch bulb up the bank and bumping the glass, and I watched it longer than I needed to because watching a moth is easier than starting the talk I knew was coming.

"Your dad was a straight one," Derek said. He tipped the can toward the nail box by my boot. "Built my sister's deck and wouldn't take the tip."

"He was," I said.

Derek pointed his chin at the maple tray. "What's in the fancy box?"

I opened it. The Gospel of John sat on top of the nails where I'd left it. Derek picked the book up, flipped a few pages with his thumb, and laughed once through his nose.

"Cut list in a Bible," he said. "That's Frank."

"Read the back cover," I said.

Derek read the back cover out loud, every line Dad had printed, including the one about a good teacher being a bad joint. He closed the book and set it on his knee. The fire popped a knot and threw a spark onto the ring stone, where it died.

"I don't buy that," Derek said. He kept the book on his knee and tapped the cover with one finger. "Jesus was a good teacher. Best one. Doesn't mean He was God. Buddhists have teachers. Muslims have a prophet. You don't have to make the man into the Maker to take the good from Him."

Manny watched the coals and turned his hot dog. Rita had gone back up to the house to check on a casserole for Sunday. The canal smelled like mud and autumn. A duck made a low sound under the far bank.

I didn't preach at Derek. Preaching wasn't going to move a man who hangs doors for a living. I reached into the nail box and took out Dad's combination square, the old Starrett with the scratched blade and the level vial clouded at one edge. From the woodpile I took a scrap of clear pine about a foot long and laid it across my knees.

"Hand me that pencil," I said.

Derek tossed me the carpenter's pencil from his shirt pocket. I caught it and turned the scrap. On three faces of the board I printed three words in Dad's block style, one word to a face: LIAR on the first, LUNATIC on the second, LORD on the third. On the fourth face, the soft edge Derek wanted, I printed TEACHER. Then I set the combination square against the LIAR face and checked it the way you check a stud for plumb before you commit a nail.

The blade sat and the vial settled. I turned the scrap to LUNATIC and checked again. Same quiet in the vial. I turned the scrap to TEACHER.

"Here's your fourth cut," I said.

I set the square on that face. The blade rocked on a high corner I'd left last summer when I planed this scrap for a different job and never fixed it. The vial refused to settle while Derek watched my hands on the tool.

"That's just a bad edge," Derek said, and he reached for another can in the cooler without standing up.

"It is," I said. "So was calling Him only a teacher. The man didn't leave that edge square. He claimed the Name. He claimed the forever. He took worship from Thomas and didn't correct him. You keep teacher on that claim and the joint opens in a year."

I turned the scrap to LORD and set the square one more time. Flush this time. The vial went still over ordinary pine, and the claim under the blade was the one Dad had marked through John's whole book in cut-list hand.

Derek drank. Manny pulled the hot dog off the hanger and blew on it. Across the canal a light came on in a second-story window on the Bethlehem side and then went off again.

"You're doing a trick with a board," Derek said. He held the Gospel out toward me as if he wanted it off his knee.

"I'm doing what Dad did with that Gospel," I said. I took the book back. "He didn't write me a lecture. He wrote me a cut list. Claims first. Then the only cuts that keep the wall standing."

I set the square across my thigh. From the box I took a sixteen-penny nail and set the point on the word LORD. Three hits with the framing hammer I'd brought from the garage seated the nail through the scrap into a short block I'd stood in the dirt for the purpose. Dad's chalk line came out next, the red plastic reel with the crank worn smooth. I snapped a line across the top of the scrap above the nail, a clean red mark the way he'd snap a wall plate before the plates went down. The chalk smelled like the powder it always smelled like. The line lay true over LORD and stopped at the edges.

My hands finished it. I put the Gospel of John back into the empty compartment, laid the combination square beside the nails, and set the chalk line on top. Then I closed the maple lid

and latched the little hook until I heard the click. The scrap with the nail through LORD I left standing in the dirt by the ring, because some marks you leave where the fire can see them.

Derek shook his can empty and crushed it against the bucket rim.

"I still think He was a teacher," Derek said. He looked at the scrap, then at the closed box, then at the lock house across the black water.

"I know," I said. "I'm not your Holy Spirit."

Manny laughed at that, soft, and threw his stick into the coals. Rita came down the bank with a plate of cookies and asked why we looked like a union meeting, and nobody gave her the long version. We ate the cookies. The fire settled to a bed of red. Derek talked about Tee Ball scores and a coach who didn't know a force play from a hole in the ground. I kept the nail box under my hand on the bucket lid and ran my thumb over the latch now and then to be sure it had caught.

I slept that night in Dad's old recliner because Rita had the guest bed. The half-double made its settling noises, pipes ticking as the heat kicked off. Around two I woke and thought I heard the lock gates move the way they move when a boat takes the chamber, the low wooden shove and the water climbing. I got up in my socks and looked out the back window at Lock 44. Chamber empty, gates still, the water held the streetlight in a flat sheet, and a plastic grocery bag had caught on the mule barn fence and fluttered without sound. I stood with my forehead near the glass and did not decide whether I had heard a boat that wasn't there or a house settling or a father who'd left me a cut list and then gone ahead through a door I can't see yet. The veil gets thin in a canal town if you let a night get quiet enough. I don't pretend I know which side of the veil made the sound.

In the morning I carried the nail box to my truck and set it on the passenger floor mat. Rita came out with coffee in two travel mugs and asked what I was keeping from the garage.

"Dad's cut list," I said. I put my palm on the lid so she could see I meant the whole tray.

She didn't ask me to explain. She kissed my cheek, told me to come back for the casserole leftovers, and stood in the driveway in Dad's old flannel shirt while I started the engine. I drove up out of Freemansburg toward Route 412 with the maple box sliding once when I took the turn by the old grist mill remains. My right hand went to the lid until the box quit moving, and I left it there through the light at the bottom of the hill.

I still take that box to jobs. I don't open it for every man on a crew. Some men aren't ready for a cut list that costs them their favorite soft answer. When a man like Derek starts in about a good teacher and only a good teacher, I don't give him a campus lecture. I hand him a square and a scrap and I let his own hands find out whether the fourth cut sits true. Most of the time he laughs and goes back to his nailer. Once in a while he gets quiet, and the quiet does more work than my talk ever did.

Dad's Gospel of John still sits in that empty compartment under the chalk line, and the block print hasn't faded: CLAIM: GOD / NO 4TH CUT. On nights like this, with the lock house dark and the cedar popping and the Lehigh moving past us toward Easton in the dark, I keep the box closed by my boot and I watch the fire. I am not here to close the big question for you. I am here to tell you what a dead carpenter wrote in the margins of John, and what his living son did with a square and a nail when a friend tried to keep a bad joint in the wall.

Throw that other piece on. Let it catch. I like a Freemansburg fire that shows me the towpath and the faces both, and leaves the canal black where the light can't reach.

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